E Mich 9 Grammar notes

Reflexive verbs

- A reflexive verb is one that **has " SE" in front of the infinitive**: *se réveiller, s'habiller, se fâcher.* This "SE" is called a **REFLEXIVE PRONOUN**, and just as the ending of the infinitive will change to agree with the person doing the action of verb, so will the reflexive pronoun change and agree:

  - **me, te, se, nous, vous, se**

  - *se coucher* *je ME couche* *nous NOUS couchons*
    se fâcher *elle SE fâche* *tu TE fâches*

- **ALL REFLEXIVE VERBS take être as their auxiliary in the perfect tense**, along with the other 16 non-reflexive verbs mentioned in F Lent 1. For a discussion about the agreement of past participles* of reflexive verbs see F Lent 7.

  - *Elle s'est réveillée* *Elles se sont vues*
    *Nous nous sommes écrit** *Ils se sont parlé**

- **What does the reflexive pronoun mean or do**? For some verbs it "**reflects**" the action of the verb back onto the person, in other words it means that they do it to themselves (*je me lève – I get MYSELF up*). In other cases, it is "reciprocal" and it means that several people perform the verb "to each other" (*nous nous écrivons – we write to each other*). And in some cases there is no English equivalent (*comment ça s'écrit – how does it write itself = is it spelled*).

- **A common mistake** is to forget to change the reflexive pronoun to the one that is needed. This happens in particular when an infinitive is used. (~~*Nous devons SE coucher*~~ instead of *nous devons NOUS coucher*.)

- The **reflexive pronoun always goes before the conjugated verb** (or infinitive):

  - *je ne me rase pas le dimanche*
    Pourquoi ne vous amusez-vous pas?

- **In the imperative, the reflexive pronouns ME and TE become MOI and TOI** in the positive imperative, and get attached to the verb with hyphens. Things behave perfectly normally in the negative imperative, however. See Lent Chapter 7.

  - *réveille-toi!* *Ne te lève pas!* *Assieds-toi!*

"Some", "any", "no" ...

- **A French noun will nearly always have to have some sort of word in front of it** *:(Tu aimes le lait? Il y a des filles)* This is not always the case in English. *(Do you like _ milk? There are _ girls there).*

- If, in English you use the word "some", then French will use one of the **PARTITIVE ARTICLES "du, de la, de l', des**). Likewise, if in English you use the word "the", French will use one of the **DEFINITE ARTICLES "le, la, l', les**".

  - *Some cheese, some beer, some water, some boys,*
  - *du fromage, de la bière, de l'eau, des garçons*

- The same applies **whenever English has a specific word in front of the noun**, you just use the French equivalent:

  - *my cheese, this beer, their water, five boys*
  - *mon fromage, cette bière, leur eau, cinq garçons.*

- The problem is in the cases mentioned at the top of the page, **where English puts in no word at all.** "*I'm allergic to _ prawns" " What's on my sandwich? _ Ham."*
  In these cases you will either use the **PARTITIVE ARTICLE** or the **DEFINITE ARTICLE**. To decide ask yourself if you are talking about:

  - **an actual, tangible quantity of the noun:** USE PARTITIVE
  - **the noun in general**: USE DEFINITE.

  - *You've got _ chocolate on your shirt :* du chocolat
  - *Did you bring _ chocolates?:* des chocolats
  - *I can't bear _ chocolate:* le chocolat
  - *There's _ chocolate all over the window:* du chocolat
  - _Chocolate is very bad for your teeth: le chocolat

- After any **negative particle** (pas, jamais etc), the PARTITIVE ARTICLE becomes just DE.

  - *Je ne mange plus de chocolat. Il ne fume jamais de cigares.*
  - *J'ai fait DE LA planche à voile, mais je n'ai pas fait DE ski.*

- **DE** rather than the other PARTITIVE ARTICLES is used after all the quantity expressions such as *"beaucoup de" "un peu de" trois kilos de"* etc. It is possible to say "*beaucoup DES*" or "*trop DU*" but this means **the word "THE"** is needed.

  - *beaucoup de chocolat* **(lots of)** *beaucoup DU chocolat* **(lots of THE)**
  - *trop de bière* **(too much)** *trop DE LA bière* **(too much of THE)**